

Candidate Project Submission

Plug-and-Play Sensing & Control Slice for a Growing Rack

Joycelyn Wirata

July 21, 2026

Contents

1	Component Selection Matrix	3
1.1	Design	3
1.2	Temperature and Humidity Sensor Evaluation	3
1.3	ESP32 Bridge Evaluation	4
1.4	Smart Plug Evaluation	4
1.5	Exhaust Fan Evaluation	5
1.6	Weakest Buy vs. Build Decision	5
2	Integration and Control Design	6
2.1	System Architecture	6
2.2	Home Assistant Integration	7
2.3	Non-Native Sensor Bridge	7
2.4	Correlation Logic	8
2.5	Failure Modes	9
2.6	Bench Testing	9
2.7	Architectural Alignment	10
3	Working Configuration	10
3.1	Home Assistant Artifacts	10
3.2	Dashboard Sketch	10
4	AI Usage Appendix	11
4.1	Tools Used	11
4.2	Important Prompts	11

4.3	AI Verification	11
4.4	Work Not Delegated	12
5	Time Allocation	12
A	Component Links	13
A.1	Temperature and Humidity Sensors	13
A.2	ESP32 Development Boards	13
A.3	Smart Plugs	13
A.4	Exhaust Fans	13

1 Component Selection Matrix

1.1 Design

The proposed sensing and control slice monitors two environmental parameters—air temperature and relative humidity—and controls a single exhaust fan. Home Assistant combines both measurements to calculate Vapor Pressure Deficit (VPD), which serves as the control variable for rack ventilation.

Environmental Parameters	Air Temperature, Relative Humidity
Actuator	Exhaust Fan
Control Variable	Vapor Pressure Deficit (VPD)
Home Assistant Role	Sensor fusion, automation, actuator control

Table 1: Selected sensing and control architecture.

1.2 Temperature and Humidity Sensor Evaluation

Product	Vendor	Price	Link
Adafruit SHT45	Adafruit	\$12.50	Adafruit
Adafruit SHT31-D	Adafruit	\$13.95	Adafruit
Seeed Grove SHT40	Seeed Studio	\$5.50	Seeed Studio

Table 2: Temperature and humidity sensor candidates.

Product	HA	Data	Reliability	Cost	Availability
Adafruit SHT45	5	5	5	4	5
Adafruit SHT31-D	5	4	5	4	5
Seeed Grove SHT40	5	4	4	5	4

Table 3: Evaluation scores (5 = best).

Selected Sensor: Adafruit SHT45 The Adafruit SHT45 was selected for the proposed design due to its superior accuracy, reliability, and straightforward ESPHome integration. The sensor includes factory calibration with ISO 17025 traceability, supports operation in condensing environments, and communicates over a standard I²C interface that is natively supported by ESPHome.

1.3 ESP32 Bridge Evaluation

Product	Vendor	Price	Link
ESP32-DEVKITM-1	Espressif	\$8	DigiKey
ESP32-S3-DEVKITC-1U-N8R8	Espressif	\$15	DigiKey
ESP32-C3-DEVKITM-1-N4X	Espressif	\$8	DigiKey

Table 4: ESP32 bridge candidates.

Product	HA	Performance	Reliability	Cost	Availability
ESP32-DEVKITM-1	5	5	5	5	5
ESP32-S3-DEVKITC-1U-N8R8	5	5	5	4	4
ESP32-C3-DEVKITM-1-N4X	5	4	4	5	5

Table 5: ESP32 bridge evaluation scores (5 = best).

Selected Bridge: ESP32-DEVKITM-1 The ESP32-DEVKITM-1 was selected because it is a mature and widely adopted platform with excellent ESPHome support. It provides more than sufficient processing capability for an I²C sensor bridge while maintaining a lower cost than the ESP32-S3. Compared to the ESP32-C3, it offers greater flexibility for future expansion while remaining broadly available from distributors such as DigiKey and Mouser.

1.4 Smart Plug Evaluation

Product	Vendor	Price	Link
Shelly Plug US Gen4	Shelly	\$25	Shelly
Eve Energy	Eve	\$40	Eve
TP-Link Tapo TP15	TP-Link	\$20	TP-Link

Table 6: Smart plug candidates.

Product	HA	Telemetry	Reliability	Cost	Availability
Shelly Plug US Gen4	5	5	5	4	5
Eve Energy	5	5	5	3	4
TP-Link Tapo TP15	5	4	4	5	5

Table 7: Smart plug evaluation scores (5 = best).

Selected Smart Plug: Shelly Plug US Gen4 The Shelly Plug US Gen4 aligns closely with Luce Labs’ preference for open protocols by supporting Matter while operating entirely on the local network. It integrates directly into Home Assistant, includes power monitoring for basic actuator health checks, and can be replaced by another Matter-compatible smart plug without modifying the automation logic.

1.5 Exhaust Fan Evaluation

Product	Vendor	Price	Link
AC Infinity AXIAL 1238	AC Infinity	\$39	AC Infinity
AC Infinity CLOUDLINE S6	AC Infinity	\$100	AC Infinity
VIVOSUN AeroZesh G6	VIVOSUN	\$104	VIVOSUN

Table 8: Exhaust fan candidates.

Product	Control	Reliability	Noise	Cost	Availability
AC Infinity AXIAL 1238	5	5	4	5	5
AC Infinity CLOUDLINE S6	5	5	5	2	5
VIVOSUN AeroZesh G6	5	4	4	2	5

Table 9: Exhaust fan evaluation scores (5 = best).

Selected Fan: AC Infinity AXIAL 1238 The AXIAL 1238 was selected because it provides reliable continuous ventilation while remaining inexpensive and simple to control through a Matter-compatible smart plug. Keeping the fan as a basic AC load ensures that all control logic remains centralized within Home Assistant rather than embedded in proprietary vendor ecosystems.

1.6 Weakest Buy vs. Build Decision

The weakest buy in the proposed architecture is the ESP32-based sensing node. Although the combination of an ESP32 and SHT45 provides excellent performance and integrates cleanly into Home Assistant through ESPHome, it introduces an additional microcontroller, firmware maintenance, and WiFi dependency.

For a single rack or small deployment, this approach aligns well with Luce Labs’ “buy before build” philosophy. However, for deployments consisting of dozens or hundreds of racks, a custom sensing node would become attractive. A purpose-built PCB integrating the temperature and humidity sensor, Matter connectivity, watchdog protection, industrial connectors, and standardized mounting would reduce cost, simplify installation, and

improve long-term maintainability while continuing to expose standard Home Assistant entities.

2 Integration and Control Design

2.1 System Architecture

Figure 1 shows the sensing and control slice for one growing rack. The Adafruit SHT45 measures temperature and relative humidity through I²C and connects to an ESP32-DEVKITM-1 running ESPHome. The ESP32 publishes sensor data to Home Assistant over WiFi. Home Assistant calculates VPD, executes automation logic, and controls the AC Infinity AXIAL 1238 exhaust fan through a Matter command sent to the Shelly Plug US Gen4. US Gen4.

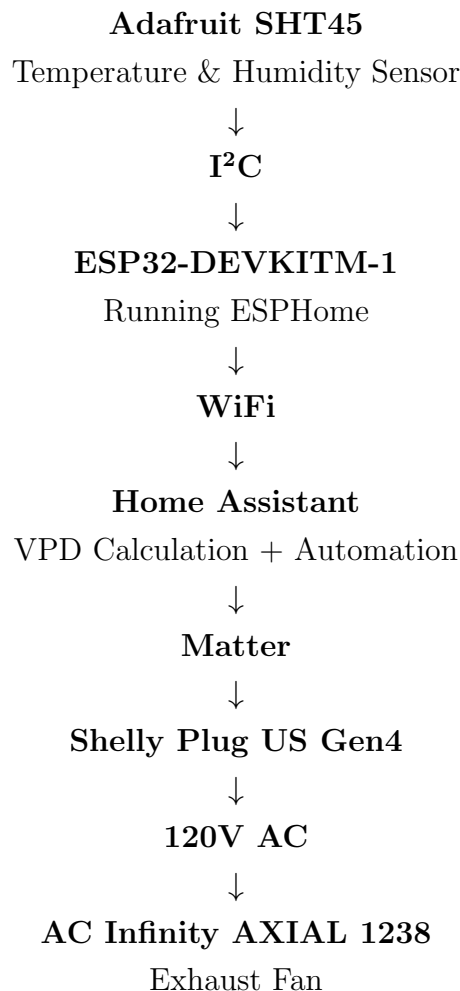


Figure 1: Proposed sensing and control architecture.

2.2 Home Assistant Integration

Temperature and Humidity Sensor

The Adafruit SHT45 communicates with the ESP32 using the I²C interface. ESPHome periodically polls the sensor and publishes the following entities to Home Assistant:

- `sensor.rack_temperature`
- `sensor.rack_humidity`

These entities are automatically discovered through the native ESPHome integration and behave identically to native Home Assistant sensors.

ESP32 Bridge

The ESP32-DEVKITM-1 runs ESPHome firmware and connects to Home Assistant through native integration. ESPHome provides automatic entity discovery and OTA firmware updates without requiring MQTT middleware.

Smart Plug

The Shelly Plug US Gen4 joins Home Assistant using the Matter integration and exposes the following entities:

- `switch.rack_fan`
- `sensor.rack_fan_power`
- `sensor.rack_fan_energy`

The smart plug acts solely as the actuator interface. All environmental decision making remains centralized within Home Assistant.

2.3 Non-Native Sensor Bridge

The Adafruit SHT45 is not a native Matter device, so the ESP32-DEVKITM-1 acts as the hardware and firmware bridge. ESPHome reads the sensor through I²C and publishes the measurements as standard Home Assistant entities.

Home Assistant interacts only with the exposed entities, making the sensing node functionally identical to a native HA device. The sensor hardware can therefore be replaced without modifying dashboards or automation logic.

Bridge Selection

Option	Reason Not Selected
MQTT Discovery	Requires an MQTT broker and additional configuration overhead.
Matter Bridge	Adds unnecessary complexity for a simple I ² C sensor node.
ESPHome	Native Home Assistant support, automatic entity discovery, OTA firmware updates, and minimal configuration.

Table 10: Comparison of sensor bridging approaches.

2.4 Correlation Logic

Home Assistant combines temperature and relative humidity measurements to calculate Vapor Pressure Deficit (VPD). VPD provides a more meaningful indicator of plant transpiration conditions than either parameter alone.

The exhaust fan is controlled according to the following thresholds.

Condition	Action
VPD > 1.2 kPa for 5 minutes	Turn exhaust fan ON
VPD < 1.0 kPa for 10 minutes	Turn exhaust fan OFF

Table 11: VPD control thresholds.

The separation between ON and OFF thresholds introduces hysteresis, preventing rapid switching. Minimum activation times reduce short cycling and extend actuator lifetime.

2.5 Failure Modes

Failure Mode	Detection	Response
Temperature sensor offline	Entity unavailable	Turn fan ON and generate Home Assistant alert.
Humidity sensor offline	Entity unavailable	Turn fan ON and generate Home Assistant alert.
Implausible sensor reading	Temperature/RH outside expected operating range or unchanged for extended period	Ignore invalid data, generate alert, and maintain fan ON as a safe state.
ESP32 offline	Device unavailable	Turn fan ON and notify operator.
Fan commanded ON but drawing 0 W	Shelly power monitoring	Generate maintenance alert indicating possible actuator failure.
Home Assistant restart	Automation reload	Restore previous actuator state.
WiFi network loss	Device unavailable	Default fan to ON until communication is restored.

Table 12: Failure modes and safe-state responses.

The proposed design adopts a ventilation-first safe state because excessive humidity presents a greater long-term risk to unattended plant growth than continuous airflow.

2.6 Bench Testing

Before deployment, the following tests would be performed:

1. Verify SHT45 measurements against a reference sensor.
2. Confirm ESPHome discovery and HA entity creation.
3. Validate VPD calculations using known temperature/RH values.
4. Test fan activation, hysteresis, and anti-short-cycling behavior.
5. Disconnect sensors and verify safe-state behavior.
6. Test WiFi loss and Home Assistant restart recovery.
7. Perform a 24-hour continuous operation test.

2.7 Architectural Alignment

This design aligns with Luce Labs' plug-and-play architecture by keeping Home Assistant as the central control layer and using open protocols including I²C, WiFi, ESPHome, and Matter. The ESP32 bridge converts a non-native sensor into a first-class Home Assistant device while preserving hardware flexibility and scalability.

3 Working Configuration

3.1 Home Assistant Artifacts

The Home Assistant configuration is organized into separate files for sensor integration, data processing, automation, and visualization.

- `esphome/rack-sensor.yaml`: ESPHome firmware configuration for the ESP32 bridge and SHT45 temperature/humidity sensor.
- `template_sensors.yaml`: Creates the VPD calculation entity from temperature and humidity measurements.
- `automations.yaml`: Implements the VPD-based exhaust fan control logic with hysteresis and anti-short-cycling.
- Dashboard sketch: Visual representation of the Home Assistant Lovelace dashboard layout.

3.2 Dashboard Sketch

The dashboard provides operators with a real-time overview of environmental conditions, actuator status, and system health.

+-----+		
	Growing Rack Dashboard	
+-----+		
Temperature:	24.3 °C	
Humidity:	62 %	
VPD:	1.08 kPa	
+-----+		
Exhaust Fan:	OFF	
Fan Power:	0 W	
Energy Usage:	0.08 kWh	
+-----+		

System Status	
ESP32 Bridge: Online	
SHT45 Sensor: Connected	
Shelly Plug: Connected	
Home Assistant: Running	
+-----+	
Historical Data	
Temperature / Humidity / VPD Trends	
+-----+	

4 AI Usage Appendix

AI tools were used to accelerate component research, Home Assistant configuration development, and document refinement.

4.1 Tools Used

- ChatGPT: Used for architecture brainstorming, ESPHome YAML drafting, and checking Home Assistant configuration consistency.
- Web search: Used to verify product availability, pricing, and protocol support.

4.2 Important Prompts

Example prompts used:

1. "Design a Home Assistant architecture using a non-native I2C sensor bridged through ESPHome."
2. "Generate a Home Assistant automation using VPD thresholds with hysteresis."
3. "Compare Matter smart plugs suitable for Home Assistant."

4.3 AI Verification

One issue encountered was that AI-generated suggestions occasionally referenced unsupported Home Assistant integrations or inaccurate product capabilities. These outputs were verified against vendor documentation before inclusion.

For example, product protocol support and Home Assistant compatibility were manually checked before selecting the Shelly Plug US Gen4.

4.4 Work Not Delegated

The final architecture decisions, product selection, tradeoffs, and failure-mode analysis were completed manually. AI was used as a productivity tool rather than replacing engineering judgment.

5 Time Allocation

The project was completed within the 6–8 hour time constraint.

Task	Time Spent
Component research and evaluation	2 hours
Architecture design and block diagram	1 hour
Home Assistant and ESPHome configuration	2 hours
Failure analysis and testing plan	1 hour
Documentation and review	1 hour
Total	7 hours

Table 13: Project time allocation.

A Component Links

The following links correspond to the products evaluated in the component selection matrix.

A.1 Temperature and Humidity Sensors

- Adafruit SHT45: [Adafruit SHT45 Temperature & Humidity Sensor](#)
- Adafruit SHT31-D: [Adafruit SHT31-D Temperature & Humidity Sensor](#)
- Seeed Grove SHT40: [Seeed Grove SHT40](#)

A.2 ESP32 Development Boards

- ESP32-DEVKITM-1: [DigiKey ESP32-DEVKITM-1](#)
- ESP32-S3-DEVKITC-1U-N8R8: [DigiKey ESP32-S3-DEVKITC-1U-N8R8](#)
- ESP32-C3-DEVKITM-1-N4X: [DigiKey ESP32-C3-DEVKITM-1-N4X](#)

A.3 Smart Plugs

- Shelly Plug US Gen4: [Shelly Plug US Gen4](#)
- Eve Energy: [Eve Energy](#)
- TP-Link Tapo TP15: [TP-Link Tapo Smart Plug](#)

A.4 Exhaust Fans

- AC Infinity AXIAL 1238: [AC Infinity AXIAL 1238](#)
- AC Infinity CLOUDLINE S6: [AC Infinity CLOUDLINE S6](#)
- VIVOSUN AeroZesh: [VIVOSUN AeroZesh G6](#)